embarrass China, there was practically no chance of a major attack on India and only those who lacked perspective thought otherwise, the idea that communism inevitably meant expansion and war was naïve, Tibetan autonomy was inevitable due to the geography, terrain and climate of Tibet, and making provisions for a Chinese attack on India would cast an intolerable burden on government finances. Nehru blithely ruled out the possibility of an attack from China based on his view that such an invasion would undoubtedly lead to a world war. A face-off between the two giants of Indian politics seemed imminent. India stood at the cusp of a 180-degree foreign policy turn. Henderson himself believed that a change in direction was on the anvil.

But at the penultimate moment, fate intervened. Already ailing and often confined to his bed, Patel's health took a drastic turn for the worse. Prone to coughing up blood and frequently losing consciousness, he was too ill to attend the fateful Cabinet meeting on 21 November where Nehru's note came up for discussion. With the heavyweight deputy prime minister absent and debilitated, none of the other ministers challenged Nehru. The anticipated showdown failed to materialize. The sole intervention came from Rajagopalachari, to little consequence – although he did visit Patel later to brief him about what had transpired.[69] Nehru's arguments triumphed – the Nehruvian consensus was born.

The aborted showdown was to be Patel's last major political act. Within weeks, he was dead – his death removing from the scene the only man capable of forcing a course correction vis-à-vis China. With Patel gone, the challenge to Nehruvianism evaporated. Tibet was abandoned at the altar of friendship with China and vapid, ineffectual slogans of anti-imperialism and world peace. India's inherited rights – the trade agencies at Yatung and Gyantse, a permanent representative in Lhasa, military escorts, telegraph lines, rest houses on the road from Sikkim – a legacy of the British empire, were surrendered for the dubious benefit of proving Nehru's (and India's) anti-colonial credentials to China and the world. The People's Republic was assiduously courted. The journey to 1962 began.